The Third Sunday of Advent

Isaiah 61:1-4, 8-11 * Psalm 126
1 Thessalonians 5:16-24 * John 1:6-8, 19-28

Prayer

Gracious God,
in this season of Advent, help us to be people
who point others toward the light of Christ.
Like John the Baptist, give us humility to know that we are not the Light,
but witnesses to the One who has come to bring hope into our world.
Open our hearts as we study your Word together.
Clear away the distractions that keep us from seeing Jesus,
and help us prepare the way for his presence in our lives.
May our words, our actions,
and our lives reflect the light of Christ to those around us.
In Jesus' name, Amen.

Opening

1. When people ask you **"Who are you?"** outside of your job or title, how do you usually describe yourself? How did John the Baptist describe himself?

2. Think of a time someone enthusiastically pointed you toward something great (a restaurant, a book, or a person). What made their recommendation so convincing?

Engaging the Text

1. How does the author define John the Baptist's core purpose, and why is it significant that he was meant to be a *witness* rather than the *Light* itself?

2. When the religious leaders press John with high-profile identity questions ("Are you the Messiah? Elijah?"), why is he so quick to deflect attention away from himself and claim only to be a "voice"?

3. John points out that the true-one-in-charge is already standing among them, yet they do not know Him. What does John's posture teach us about humility in ministry and witness?

4. In what areas of life do we feel the pressure to build our own spotlight or status, rather than acting like a "voice in the wilderness" pointing to Jesus?

5. How can we practically help one another point to Christ in our everyday workplaces, families, and neighborhoods this week?

Application Activity

The 30-Second "Good Review" Challenge

John's job was to testify or give a review of the Light. This fast-paced activity helps group members practice enthusiastically recommending things before turning that energy toward their faith.

- **The Setup:** Take 30 seconds to passionately pitch something ordinary that they absolutely love (a specific coffee brand, a hiking trail, a vacuum cleaner, a life-saving app).
- **The Pivot:** "*Notice how natural, easy, and authentic it feels to point people to something good that we love? How can we channel that same unforced, genuine attitude when we speak about Jesus to others?*"